The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra Called Mahābala

Āryamahābalanāmamahāyānasūtra · Toh 947 · Derge Kangyur
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The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra Called Mahābala, known in Sanskrit as the Ārya Mahābala Nāma Mahāyāna Sūtra and in Tibetan as Pakpa Tobpoche Zhejawa Tekpa Chenpö Do, is a Mahāyāna scripture centered on Mahābala, the wrathful protective deity whose name means "Great Strength." The text opens on the great Mount Īṣādhara, where the Buddha is teaching in the presence of the bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi. It then describes the arrangement of a sacred image or maṇḍala, with the Buddha seated on a flaming lotus throne and the four-armed Mahābala at his right, holding a yak-tail whisk, a club, and a noose and making a gesture of homage. Combining sūtra framing with ritual and visualization instructions typical of early tantric practice, the work is concerned with protection and the invocation of Mahābala's power. It is Toh 947 in the Kangyur, where it belongs to the collection of dhāraṇī texts, the incantations and protective formulas gathered among the tantric scriptures.

In the language of India: ārya mahābala nāma mahāyānva sūtra

In the language of Tibet: The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra Called Mahābala.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was teaching the Dharma on the great Mount Īṣādhara. Then the blessed bodhisattva great being Vajrapāṇi, praised, extolled, honored and delighted by all the buddhas, was also present right there.

Then the Buddha, the Blessed One, comforting beings with his hand, is seated in the east on a lotus seat garlanded with flames blazing all around. To the right of the Blessed One is Mahābala, four-armed. In one hand he holds a yak-tail whisk, and with one hand he makes the gesture of homage. In his right hand he holds a club, and in his left he holds a noose. His tawny hair stands on end and his eyes are red. Below him is the Blessed One Vajradhara with his retinue. To his right is Sumbha, king of vidyā-mantras. To his left is Amṛtakuṇḍalin.

Then the heart mantras are set out like a tawny moon. The heart mantras are Kilikila, the dhāraṇī of the Soaring One, Red Body, Vajravidāraṇa and Vast Vajra. These are the supreme heart mantras. Near Mahāraudra, king of

vidyā-mantras, is noble Māmakī. Below noble Amṛtakuṇḍalin are Vajrāṅkuśa and Vajraśṛṅkhalā. On the inner sides of the door the two wrathful ones, Vajramudgara and Vajradaṇḍa, are placed facing forward.

On the left side is the Blessed One, noble Avalokiteśvara, with his retinue. To the right of the Blessed One is Pāṇḍaravāsinī. Below her are Tārā and Bhṛkuṭī. To the left is Hayagrīva, king of vidyā-mantras, together with a hundred thousand bodhisattva great beings, these and others.

Likewise, in the east are the moon, the sun, Dhṛtarāṣṭra and Indra. In the quarter of fire is Agni, surrounded by the great sages of fire. In the south are Yama and Viṣṇu. In the quarter of Nairṛti is the lord of the rākṣasas, surrounded by the mātṛkās. In the west is the lord of the nāgas, surrounded by nāgas and others. In the quarter of the wind is Vāyu with his retinue. In the north is Kubera with his retinue. In the quarter of Īśāna is Īśāna, surrounded by his hosts. And there are Śakra, lord of the gods, Viṣṇu, Mahābrahmā, and, besides these, immeasurable, countless, incalculable sons of the gods of the Pure Abodes. The Buddha, the Blessed One, with his retinue, is as before.

Then the Blessed One said, "Lord of Secrets, Vajrapāṇi, for this practitioner of this sūtra I shall fully and extensively explain this foundation of secret mantra."

Homage to the Three Jewels. Homage to Vajrapāṇi the Fierce, the great general of the yakṣas.

oṃ kili kila vajra
To Kilikila, svāhā. To the crown of the head, svāhā. To the forehead, svāhā. To the eyes, svāhā. To the Ferocious One, svāhā. To the Exceedingly Ferocious One, svāhā. To the Vajra Noose, svāhā. To the Red-Bodied One, svāhā. To Vajrapāṇi, svāhā. To the one with a noose in his hand, svāhā. To the one with a sword in his hand, svāhā. To the one with an axe in his hand, svāhā. To the bow-holder, svāhā. To the pestle-holder, svāhā. To the one with a wheel in his hand, svāhā. To the one with a trident in his hand, svāhā. To the heart mantra, svāhā. To the near-heart mantra, svāhā. To fierce Kilikila, svāhā. To young Kilikila, svāhā. To red Kilikila, svāhā. To Mahābala, svāhā. To the one with matted locks, svāhā. To the pot-bellied one, svāhā. To the wild wrathful one, svāhā. To Yama, svāhā. To the rākṣasa, svāhā. To the rākṣasa Yamunā, svāhā. To Mahāraudra, svāhā. To the cloud, svāhā. To the mountain-holder, svāhā. To the holder of Mount Īṣādhara, svāhā. To the Vajra Club, svāhā. To the Great Terrifier, svāhā. To the one with a terrifying body, svāhā. To the Threatener,

svāhā. To the Vajra Chain, svāhā. To the Vajra Bolt, svāhā. To the Vajra Body, svāhā. To the Soaring One, svāhā. To the nectar, svāhā. To the holder of austerities, svāhā. To the hook, svāhā. To the Unfailing One, svāhā. To the king of uṣṇīṣas, svāhā. To the white-colored one, svāhā. To the blue-green-colored one, svāhā. To the pendulous one, svāhā. To the elephant, svāhā. To the hand of cattle-increase, svāhā. To the magical display of Māra, svāhā. To the one with a snake for a girdle, svāhā. To the vajra kīla, svāhā. To both hands, svāhā. To ā Vajra, svāhā. To the blazing maker of light, svāhā. To the vajra of steadfast intelligence, svāhā. To the sprout, svāhā. To the maker of light, svāhā. To the one who destroys with the vajra, svāhā. To the Vajra Net, svāhā. To the Vajra Terrifier, svāhā. To the Vajra Fist, svāhā. To the one who scatters the clouds, svāhā. To the bringer of rain, svāhā. To the Vajra Hook, svāhā. To the vajra heart mantra, svāhā. To the vajra near-heart mantra, svāhā. To the king of thumbs, svāhā. To the king of clubs, svāhā. To the king of armor, svāhā. oṃ ṅhriṃ oṃ

Homage to the Three Jewels. Homage to Vajrapāṇi the Fierce, the great general of the yakṣas.

oṃ hulu hulu tiṣṭha tiṣṭha bandha bandha hana hana amṛte hūṃ phaṭ svāhā oṃ amṛte hūṃ phaṭ svāhā

To Dhṛtarāṣṭra, svāhā. To Virūpākṣa, svāhā. To Virūḍhaka, svāhā. To Kubera, svāhā. To Indra, svāhā. To Agni, svāhā. To all the great sages, svāhā. To the sun, svāhā. To the moon, svāhā. To Yama, svāhā. To Viṣṇu, svāhā. To the lord of the rākṣasas, svāhā. To the lord of the nāgas, svāhā. To Vāyu, svāhā. To Īśāna, svāhā. To the consort of Īśāna, svāhā. To Śakra, svāhā. To the son of the god of wealth, svāhā. To Mahāvajra, svāhā. To Mahābrahmā, svāhā. To the Earth, svāhā. To Sarasvatī, svāhā. To the goddess Śrī, svāhā. To the goddess who turns back austerities, svāhā.

If one keeps this great vidyā-mantra, this king of vidyā-mantras of Mahābala, in the place of the maṇḍala and holds it in mind, it will protect, guard and shelter.

and all activities will also be accomplished.

Homage to the Buddha, to the Dharma, to the Saṅgha, to the pratyekabuddhas, and to the whole Saṅgha of noble śrāvakas. Homage to the elder of great wisdom, Śāriputra. Homage to all the bodhisattvas, headed by Maitreya. Homage to those who have rightly gone. Homage to those who have rightly entered. Homage to Vajradhara and his retinue.

tadyathā mune mune mahāmune kilikila mahākilikiladhike kaṭa kaṭa kaṭa mahākaṭa śama śama śama mahāśama śātri śātri śātri śānta śānta śānta danta danta danta dhīra dhīra dhīra mahāmeghā dura dura hari hari hari kuṭṭi kuṭṭi kuṭṭi chinda chinda chinda bhindha bhindha bhindha sarvaduṣṭāna gumu gumu gumu hara hara hara prāṇān damani damni ṭa ṭa ṭa ṭha ṭha ṭha ḍā ḍā ḍā ḍā ḍā ḍā ca ca ca ca ca ca paca paca paca daha daha daha hūṃ hūṃ hūṃ he he he phaṭ phaṭ phaṭ śabari śabari śabari mātaṃgi caṇḍāli hu hu hu juhu juhu juhu hatā pratyarthina cili cili cili phaṭ phaṭ phaṭ tiṣṭha tiṣṭha tiṣṭha tiṣṭhathi tiṣṭhathi tiṣṭhathi mātikramatha mataṃgi hūṃ hūṃ hūṃ he he he

If you do not stay, your hands, feet, mouth, throat, eyes, heart and all your speech will be bound! They will be snatched away!

jvala jvala jvala dundhu dundhu dundhu bandhu bandhu bandhu nīla nīla nīlāṅga vajradhāra

Remember the heart-essence called Mahābala!

koṭi koṭi koṭini sarvabhūtāni vajramāli vajradhāra vajra aṭṭahāsa cartu nartu martu kuru kuru huru huru huru

Remember, great being!

hūṃ hūṃ hūṃ he he he phaṭ phaṭ phaṭ caṇḍa caṇḍa caṇḍa mahācaṇḍa hurtu hurtu hurtu muru muru muru gṛhna gṛhna gṛhna vajrapāṇi hana hana mama sarvaśatrūṇān mūrtini tāḍaya phaṭ kuru kuru kuru

Do not act against the activity of Vajrapāṇi! If one transgresses the sacred commitment, the commitment is torn apart, and one will also have deceived the Tathāgata. These are the bases of the secret mantra.

cu cu cu hara hara hara phuṭu phuṭu phuṭu tapani tapani tapani pacani pacani pacani

Remember the heart-essence of Vajrapāṇi, blessed by the Tathāgata!

cili cili cili phulu phulu phulu phu phu phu

Blessed One, if I should act against this heart-essence, may I incur the five deeds of immediate retribution proclaimed by the Tathāgata!

darphu carphu narphu

Homage to Vajradhara and his retinue. May these bases of the secret mantra be accomplished for me, svāhā. Homage to Vajradhara of great splendor, svāhā. oṃ hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ phaṭ svāhā

Then, at that time, the radiance of the light rays of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Śākyamuni, blazing all around, passed beyond the great trichiliocosm, the three-thousandfold world-system, and all the abodes of Māra were seen to blaze all around, to blaze intensely, to spread everywhere and blaze until they became a single mass of flame. When this happened, the evil Māra, holding in his hands swords, discuses, bows, arrows and other weapons, produced many obstructive magical displays.

Then, in that very instant, the evil Māra, together with all the young gods of Māra's realm, went with a great magical display of Māra to where the Blessed One was. When this happened, a furious Wrathful One appeared: red in color, his eyes reddish-yellow like honey, fangs bared, unbearable, his tawny hair bristling upward, holding a club in his right hand and in his left a vajra, adorned with snakes, and wearing a skirt of tiger skin. He appeared everywhere toward the east, across world-systems as many as the grains of sand of twenty-one Ganges rivers, and likewise toward the south, the west and the north.

Then the evil Māra and hundreds of thousands of trillions of obstructing spirits trembled before the furious Wrathful One. The evil Māra, stupefied and tormented, was hurled down and, heedless of his life, was bound by the Lord of Secrets Vajrapāṇi with the five bonds of the noose. When this happened, the gods of the Yāma, Tuṣita, Nirmāṇarati and Paranirmitavaśavartin heavens made offerings to the Blessed One as best they could, with incense, flowers, victory banners, various pennants and so forth, and then sat down to one side.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being, the Lord of Secrets Vajrapāṇi, praised and lauded by all the buddhas and made to rejoice, and with the consent of the Blessed One, for the sake of all sentient beings and for the benefit and happiness of gods and humans, spoke from within the great tantra of the supreme vidyā-mantras these bases of the secret mantra, called the King of Vidyā-Mantras of the Great Power of Mahābala, Who Overcomes Adversaries with Immeasurable Power, also called Granting All Wished-for Aims.

Whoever holds it, keeps it, reads it, teaches it extensively and correctly to others, honors it, esteems it highly, serves it or worships it will have entered all maṇḍalas. All the secret mantras performed by adversaries will also be demolished, destroyed and overturned.

Thus did the Blessed One Vajradhara speak what comes from within the great tantra of the supreme vidyā-mantras. Then the Lord of Secrets Vajrapāṇi, with

the consent of the Blessed One, spoke this basis of the secret mantra of Mahābala, Who Overcomes Adversaries with Immeasurable Power, called Granting All Wished-for Aims:

oṃ vajrakrodha mahābala hana daha paca vidhvansay jaṭilampobhara ucchuṣmakrodha hūṃ phaṭ svāhā

Then the Lord of Secrets Vajrapāṇi said this to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, if any son of noble family or daughter of noble family, having heard this Dharma discourse, takes it up, holds it, reads it, teaches it extensively to others as well, honors it, or makes offerings to it, they will be empowered in all maṇḍalas."

The Lord of Secrets Vajrapāṇi spoke again: "One who holds the heart of Mahābala cannot be harmed by yakṣas or the children of yakṣas, by rākṣasas or the children of rākṣasas, by kumbhāṇḍas or the children of kumbhāṇḍas, by garuḍas or the children of garuḍas, by nāgas or the children of nāgas, by gandharvas or the children of gandharvas, by piśācas or the children of piśācas, by unmādas or the children of unmādas, by ḍākinīs or the children of ḍākinīs, by adepts, by snake-holders and the like, by apasmāras, by pūtanas, by vetālas and the like, by any of the cutting grahas, or by apasmāras and the like."

Then the Blessed One said to the Lord of Secrets Vajrapāṇi, "Lord of Secrets Vajrapāṇi, excellent, excellent! It is emptiness. It is the emptiness of the ultimate. It is the emptiness of the final limit. It is the emptiness of emptiness. It is the great emptiness. It is the emptiness of suchness."

Then the Lord of Secrets Vajrapāṇi said to the Blessed One, "Whoever teaches this sūtra becomes worthy of being offered to, bowed to, honored, and circumambulated."

Then the Blessed One Vajrapāṇi spoke the basis of the secret mantra of Mahābala, Who Overcomes Adversaries with Immeasurable Power:

oṃ hūṃ hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ phaṭ phaṭ You who bear a trident in your hand, fierce one, hūṃ hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ phaṭ phaṭ oṃ jyotirnāda hūṃ hūṃ hūṃ oṃ oṃ oṃ phaṭ phaṭ phaṭ To Mahābala, svāhā

oṃ Vajra Wrathful One, Mahābala, hana daha vacamtha vikira vidhvansaya jaṭilalaṃbodara ucchuṣma krodha hūṃ phaṭ

oṃ jvala jvala sarva duṣṭana stambhaya stambhaya durācarāna duṣṭana nivāraya Protect me, protect me! svāhā

oṃ ananta vijaya mahācaṇḍi hūṃ phaṭ svāhā oṃ dhrika hūṃ phaṭ oṃ śiri śiro mālini sini sini śiśini śiśini oṃ sarva ātmaja mahātejo vajra aśani vajra pāśa anu praviśa sarva duṣṭan stambhaya stambhaya hūṃ phaṭ oṃ hūṃ bandha bandha hūṃ oṃ ananta vijaya mahācaṇḍi hūṃ phaṭ oṃ phaṭ phaṭ phaṭ vajra krodha hūṃ phaṭ oṃ vajra kartari kara kara chindha chindha hūṃ phaṭ oṃ vajra krodha mahābala dhaka dhaka jvala jvala hūṃ phaṭ oṃ vipur rakṣa vajra pañcara hūṃ phaṭ oṃ kili kila vajra vajrir bhūr bandha bandha hūṃ phaṭ oṃ vajra krodha mahābala ākarṣaya ākarṣaya ākarṣaya hūṃ phaṭ oṃ vajra krodha mahābala dara dara dhāraya dhāraya hūṃ phaṭ oṃ vajra krodha mahābala hana hana daha daha dara dara dāraya dāraya paṭaya paṭaya moṭaya moṭaya hūṃ phaṭ oṃ vajra krodha mahāpaya taḍa taḍa tāḍaya tāḍaya hūṃ phaṭ oṃ vajra krodha mahābala jvala jvala vrajvala vrajvala dīvya dīvya dīpaya dīpaya hūṃ phaṭ oṃ curu curu ucchuṣma krodha śikha hara hara hūṃ phaṭ

Homage to the Three Jewels. Homage to the great yakṣa general, Vajrapāṇi the fierce.

oṃ vajra krodha mahābala caṇḍa hana daha paca matha vikari vidhvansaya Blessed One, come here, come here! hana hana hara hara daha daha paca paca vidhvansaya vidhvansaya You who are worshipped by the lords of the gods and asuras, born from the very self of all, of great splendor, suru suru muru muru kuru kuru ghuru ghuru kurva kurva mahākurva vikurva kunaṭṭi kunaṭṭi naṭi naṭi śini śini khini khini kha kha khāhi khāhi khuru khuru tuṭu tuṭa traṭṭa traṭṭa turu turu Lord of the bhūtas, lord of the nāgas, Frenzied Wrathful One who destroys the cities of the asuras, Mahābala, dhama dhama kara kara kuru kuru suru suru hūṃ phaṭ hana hana hūṃ phaṭ daha daha hūṃ phaṭ paca paca hūṃ phaṭ hrī hūṃ hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ phaṭ phaṭ svāhā oṃ culu culuru svāhā oṃ vajra krodha mahābala sarva duṣṭan stambhaya stambhaya mohaya mohaya hūṃ phaṭ oṃ ha ha sara sara visara visara ghātayaghātaya oṃ visara santraya hūṃ oṃ vajra krodha mahābala hara hara kha kha khāhi khāhi nāśaya nāśaya hūṃ phaṭ hūṃ hūṃ māma māma phaṭ oṃ vajra krodha ni Protect me, protect me! svāhā oṃ mahābala vajradhara kara kara bhandha bhandha hūṃ phaṭ oṃ jvala grasa ucchuṣma sagara hūṃ

"Those sixty-four vajra messenger women will also protect, guard, and keep one hidden."

Vajrapāṇi said: "Whoever holds this dhāraṇī will fare well. They will overcome poison and will revive the dead. They cannot be harmed by enemies. They will have many children. The region too will become bright. All secret mantras will also be accomplished. They will be able to perform all rites. Those seized by malevolent beings will be revived with water from the cupped hand. All poisons too will be rendered nonpoisonous. Boys and girls dwelling in the womb will also be born easily. If this sūtra is kept for three days, it will bring increase. If it is kept for seven days, it will bring great pacification."

Then Īśāna, lord of the bhūtas, surrounded by many tens of millions of vidyādharas, rose from the circle of the assembly, bowed his head at the feet of the bodhisattva mahāsattva, the Lord of Secrets Vajrapāṇi, and spoke these words to the bodhisattva mahāsattva Vajrapāṇi:

"Bodhisattva mahāsattva, please explain the maṇḍala, together with its secret, of Mahābala: whose teaching is unobstructed; who overpowers adversaries with immeasurable strength; who delights Vajrapāṇi; who is honored by the gods, the asuras, Brahmā, and Indra; who terrifies yakṣas, rākṣasas, vetālas, pūtanas, and kaṭapūtanas; who with the vajra utterly destroys the unmādas, the banishers, the killers, and the witherers, the door bars, the contraptions, and the bolts; and who performs all activities."

Then the entire assembly gave their "Excellent, excellent!" to Īśāna, the lord of the bhūtas.

Then the Blessed One raised the vajra and, seated in the manner of one seated upon a vajra, gazed upon the maṇḍala of the entire assembly. There were the samādhi called Vajra, the Terrible Great Wrathful One Who Utterly Destroys All the Maṇḍalas of Māras; the samādhi called Great Compassion for All Sentient Beings; the samādhi called Blazing and Shining Light Rays; the samādhi called Fully Displaying the Joy of All Dharmas; the samādhi called Destroying the Domain of All Māras; the samādhi called the Characteristic of Mudrā; the samādhi called the Domain of All Sentient Beings; the samādhi called the Unmoving; the samādhi called the Dharma Body; the samādhi called the Dharma Door; and the samādhi called Mahābala.

Then the Blessed One Vajrapāṇi, with restraint, raised the vajra. Then, standing in the manner of a vajra set upon a lotus, he gazed upon the maṇḍala of the entire assembly and entered the samādhi called Vajra, the Terrible Frenzied Wrathful One, Whose Body Is Adorned with a Belt of Snakes, Who Brings Delight. The very moment he entered that absorption, he himself saw

many hundreds of thousands of millions of obstructors trembling, tormented by the Frenzied Wrathful One. Burning, they cried out. Giving up all hope of life, they thought it was the eon of fire, and weeping in wretched voices they went before the bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi and said, "Blessed One, please protect us! Bodhisattva, please protect us! Blessed One, we are tormented and stupefied by the Blessed One's Frenzied Wrathful One, and in our distress we have no regard left for our lives."

Then the Blessed One, the great bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi, rose from that samādhi and said to all the maṇḍalas of Māras, "Oh! This great wrathful one has great miraculous power, great might!"

They replied, "Blessed One, it is so. Oh! This great wrathful one has great miraculous power, great might!"

Then the Blessed One, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Vajrapāṇi, looking with the lion's gaze, spoke to Īśāna, the lord of the bhūtas, the maṇḍala of the Frenzied Wrathful One together with its secret:

oṃ vajra krodha mahābala hana daha paca vidhvansaya jaṭilambodhara ucchuṣma krodha hūṃ phaṭ a āṃ mahāṃ svāhā

"Friends, whoever enters the maṇḍala of this wrathful one Mahābala will accomplish all his activities. He will not meet his death by untimely death. His body will not be harmed by any fierce rites or by any illness. Humans, obstructors, and vināyakas will find no opening against him. All people will be pleased with him. All his enemies will vanish. If one enters here, all secret mantras will be accomplished. The rites of all the wrathful ones, too, will be accomplished effortlessly and spontaneously. If one is empowered here, one will be completely freed from all inauspiciousness. One will be blessed with glory.

"Then, one who has performed the preliminary practice of the great wrathful one ten thousand times; who performs the maṇḍala of the great wrathful one; who is grateful; who knows the tantra; who keeps the eight branches of the poṣadha; who has gone for refuge to the Three; who has the awakening mind; who has a mind of loving-kindness; who has become compassionate; who has seen the maṇḍala; who has been empowered; and who has been given the transmission by the gurus; one who holds and recites this king of vidyā-mantras called Mahābala, the rite that destroys all māras and all hostile minds, will not be overcome by any māras or enemies. He will be freed from all yakṣas, rākṣasas, pretas, piśācas, pūtanas, ḍākinīs, apasmāras, sorcerers,

snake-holders, and all the rest, and from every fear. He will be freed from all untimely death. He will be freed from all killing and binding. He will be freed from all mutilation. He will be freed from all the fears of being dulled, paralyzed, bewildered, and the like. He will be freed from all the fears of nāgas. He will be freed from all inauspiciousness.

"Whatever poor being holds, recites, keeps in mind, or recollects this Dharma discourse at the three times of day will be freed from all the suffering of poverty. In a time of famine, if Mahābala is recited seven times, rain will fall from a great cloud. If rain does not fall, the lives of the cloud gods will wither. The nāga kings, such as the nāga king Black One, the nāga king Wheel, and the nāga king Ananta, will send down rain from a great cloud. If they do not send it down, their lives will wither.

"In accordance with the rite described above, in some region, on a riverbank, on the seashore, by a lakeshore, or at the site of a stūpa, one should make a great offering to the bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi. Having made offerings of white sandalwood, karavīra flowers, red lotuses, atimuktaka flowers, campaka flowers, victory banners, red flags, and so on, and vases filled with scented water, and so on, whoever holds and recites this sūtra will not be overcome by adversaries, even when entering any battle whatever. All beings will be pleased with him."

They will be completely freed from all that is inauspicious. If one ties Mahābala to the top of a victory banner and goes to the front line of battle, one will be invincible to adversaries. If one writes the secret mantra on birch bark and ties it to the crown of the head, weapons on the battlefield will fall like flowers.

Then that Māra circumambulated the Blessed One three times, sat down to one side, and asked, "What is it that is called Mahābala?"

The Blessed One said, "What is called Mahābala is the Tathāgata. What is called Mahābala is the Dharma. What is called Mahābala is the collection of the Dharma. What is called Mahābala is the way of the Dharma. What is called Mahābala is the Great Vehicle. What is called Mahābala is Vajrapāṇi."

Then the evil Māra said, "Lord of Secrets Vajrapāṇi, excellent, excellent! I go for refuge. I go for refuge to the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha. Blessed One, excellent, excellent! I shall take up the precepts of a layman.

For happiness, liberation, and the higher realms,
For the learned and for sentient beings,

For the benefit of all the holy ones,
I shall uphold Mahābala."

Then, seeing that the evil Māra delighted in the Dharma and was glad and pleased, the Blessed One spoke these words: "This sūtra of Mahābala, king of vidyā-mantras, frees sentient beings from the sufferings of the hells, the animals, the hungry ghosts, and the world of Yama. One who keeps it will be a king of the gods for twenty thousand eons. For limitless eons he will be a wheel-turning monarch ruling the four continents. It establishes him in unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. This heart essence of Mahābala, king of vidyā-mantras, brings accomplishment whether one is clean or unclean, whether one has kept a fast or has not kept a fast, and even if one engages in sexual intercourse. No obstacle will arise for such a person."

Then Subhūti, who was present in that very assembly, asked, "Blessed One, how should Mahābala, king of vidyā-mantras, be upheld? What supreme thing does it bestow?"

The Blessed One said, "Put your question to Vajrapāṇi."

Subhūti said, "Vajrapāṇi, how should Mahābala, king of vidyā-mantras, be upheld? What supreme thing does it give?"

Vajrapāṇi said, "It gives grain. It gives clothing. It gives silver. It gives gold. It gives cattle. Whatever supreme thing one wishes for, that supreme thing it gives."

Subhūti said, "Is that what is called the general fruit?"

Vajrapāṇi said, "Subhūti, it is just so. Sentient beings obscured by afflictions abide in the time of the fruit. Through the time of the fruit they abide for the sake of good qualities. Through the aim of good qualities, it establishes them on the path of unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening."

Subhūti said:
"Vajrapāṇi, excellent, excellent!
Endowed with secret characteristics,
Mahābala is endowed with wisdom,
Perfect in its secret characteristics.
Empowered from the crown, its mind is keen;
It is truly endowed with the marks,
Great in generosity, discipline, and wisdom,

Great in miraculous power and great in strength,
Renowned for its great might, and great in merit:
Mahābala, the summit of good qualities.
In order to empower this sūtra,
Eight thousand buddhas came there."

Through this very sūtra, the bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi will place the hand of fearlessness upon one's crown and bring about well-being. Whoever keeps this secret mantra on the ground, on a mountain, on the bank of a river, or near the ocean will be free from fear of every danger.

Then the bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi said to the Blessed One, "Whoever holds this sūtra or reads it, and also teaches it to others extensively and correctly, will live a hundred years free of disease."

Vajrapāṇi asked further, "What is the name of this Dharma discourse? How should it be held?"

The Blessed One said, "Hold this sūtra as The Emanation of the Tathāgata. Hold it also as The Sun of the Dharma. Hold it also as The Moon of the Dharma. Hold it also as The Accomplishment of All Aims. Hold it also as The Dharma Cloud of All Tathāgatas. Hold it also as The Dhāraṇī-Mantra That Purifies All Misdeeds. Hold it also as The King Who Brings Accomplishment to All Holders of Vidyā-Mantras. Hold it also as The Perfection of Wisdom. Hold it also as The Dharmadhātu That Goes Before All Tathāgatas. Hold it also as Mahābala, King of Vidyā-Mantras.

"Lord of Secrets Vajrapāṇi, whoever takes up this sūtra, holds it, reads it, has it written, reveres it, regards it as supreme, attends upon it, and makes offerings to it will thereby have made offerings to the buddhas and bodhisattvas of the past, the future, and the present. They will have made offerings to the stūpas containing the relics of those of the past, the future, and the present."

Vajrapāṇi said, "Blessed One, excellent, excellent! I shall uphold this teaching of the most profound Dharma, this teaching of the Dharma adorned with the qualities of miraculous display."

The Blessed One said, "Vajrapāṇi, any son or daughter of noble family who holds this sūtra, the beings who are hostile to them will come to ruin like a tree on a riverbank. If one makes offerings to it with perfumes, flowers, incense, victory banners, various flags, and so on, one will be endowed with an

immeasurable heap of merit. No obstacle will arise for such a person. In whatever place this sūtra is kept, it will be worshiped by the world with its gods and humans. If one brings to mind Mahābala, king of vidyā-mantras, which binds all obstructors and vināyakas, the eight thousand buddhas, the bodhisattva great beings, the great sages, and the gods, nāgas, and gandharvas will all rejoice."

At the time when they rejoiced in this dhāraṇī-mantra of Mahābala, the Tathāgata Śākyamuni spoke these words: "Lord of Secrets, Vajrapāṇi, whoever does not show respect to this sūtra will be born as a being in the eight great hells. Lord of Secrets, Vajrapāṇi, whoever shows respect to this sūtra, honors it and makes offerings to it will come to possess an immeasurable heap of merit. If one writes out its letters or hears its words, one will attain the irreversible path of awakening."

Vajrapāṇi said, "The Dharma of the Sage is inconceivable and extremely profound. Among sentient beings, whoever thinks wrongly of the inconceivable will be driven mad."

The Blessed One said, "Lord of Secrets, Vajrapāṇi, I shall explain this sūtra for the benefit of sentient beings. I shall explain it in order to remove the obscurations of all sentient beings, to pacify, to increase, to empower, to free them from all that is inauspicious, to bless them with glory, to purify all evil deeds, and to bring all sentient beings to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening."

Therefore a hundred thousand tathāgatas came forward, circumambulated the Tathāgata Śākyamuni three times, joined their palms, and rejoiced, saying, "Excellent, excellent! It has been well explained!"

Then the Tathāgata Śākyamuni spoke in turn to those buddhas: "Blessed Ones, excellent, excellent is what you have well spoken."

The Blessed One said, "Through the power of this teaching of the secret Dharma of Mahābala, the bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi saw the hearts of all the hostile obstructors and vināyakas tremble and shake."

Homage to the Three Jewels! Homage to the great general of the yakṣas, the fierce Vajrapāṇi!

tadyathā oṃ hana hana vajra daha daha vajra paca paca vajra matha matha vajra jvala prajvala suru suru muru muru kaṭaṅkaye jaye vijaye ajite aparājite mārasenyapramardanāye svāhā

The Blessed One said, "Lord of Secrets, Vajrapāṇi, threaten, threaten all obstructors and vināyakas! Bind them, bind them! Bind them utterly! Make accomplished those who are not accomplished! Make the accomplished tamed! Make the tamed not go to waste! Make all the buddhas and bodhisattvas descend! All you gods and nāgas, come here, come here! Through the power of the wrathful Mahābala I shall bring about what is good."

Then Mañjuśrī, who had become a youth, rose from his seat, draped his upper robe over one shoulder, set his right knee on the ground, bowed with joined palms toward the Blessed One, and said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, what is the characteristic of the impermanence of all formations?"

The Blessed One said, "Bodhisattva Mañjuśrī, you who have become a youth, listen! All formations are like a city of gandharvas. All formations are like lightning and clouds. All formations are like a house and like foam. All formations are like a lamp. All formations are like a water bubble. All formations are like a plantain tree. All formations are like the shapes in a painting. All formations are like a flower. All formations are like a dream. These formations are like a wheel of happiness and suffering. These formations are like a river of happiness and suffering. Because they become turbulent, they are like the ocean. They are like the stars.

"Sentient beings do not consider the arising of these formations; they do not see it, do not know it, do not meet with it. The Tathāgata alone sees it. The Tathāgata alone meets with it. The Tathāgata alone knows it. He knows all formations as having the single characteristic of emptiness. He knows them as having the characteristic of the emptiness of the ultimate. He knows them as having the characteristic of the emptiness of what is beyond extremes. He knows them as having the characteristic of the emptiness of emptiness. He knows them as having the characteristic of the great emptiness. He knows them as having the characteristic of the emptiness of suchness.

"Mañjuśrī, you who have become a youth, bodhisattvas who see this very characteristic and, knowing this very characteristic, practice, practice the perfection of generosity. Likewise they practice the perfections of moral discipline, patience, diligence, meditative concentration and wisdom. One who knows this very characteristic is called a bodhisattva."

Then the bodhisattva, the great being, the noble Avalokiteśvara circumambulated the Blessed One three times, sat down to one side, and said, "Blessed One, by what characteristic, and in what way, is this sūtra called an

emanation of the Tathāgata?"

The Blessed One said, "Noble Avalokiteśvara, when the Tathāgata has passed into complete nirvāṇa, this sūtra will perform the deeds of the Tathāgata; by that characteristic it is called an emanation of the Tathāgata. When this sūtra has completely disappeared, the teaching of the Tathāgata will completely disappear; by that characteristic it is called an emanation of the Tathāgata. While this sūtra lives on and remains, the teaching of the Tathāgata also lives on and remains; by that characteristic it is called an emanation of the Tathāgata. All the tathāgatas, too, pay homage to this sūtra; by that characteristic it is called an emanation of the Tathāgata."

Then the noble Avalokiteśvara rejoiced in the Blessed One and said, "I shall do as you command, and I shall go to the presence of whoever holds this sūtra."

The Blessed One said, "Through the power of this very sūtra, the buddhas, all the bodhisattvas and all the gods will come as well."

And all the gods said, "Excellent, excellent! We too delight in granting the sublime attainment, and all the buddhas and bodhisattvas will also grant this very sublime attainment."

The Blessed One said, "Lord of Secrets, Vajrapāṇi, the secret essence of Mahābala grants every happiness to all sentient beings."

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Vajrapāṇi, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, by what characteristic is this sūtra called 'Preceded by the Dharma Realm'?"

The Blessed One said, "Son of noble family, on the day when thirty-two days had passed after all the tathāgatas had appeared, they taught the Dharma by means of this very sūtra on the great Mount Īṣādhara. By that characteristic it is called 'Preceded by the Dharma Realm.' Through the power of this very sūtra, all the buddhas and bodhisattvas abide in the first arising of the mind of awakening. By that characteristic it is called 'Preceded by the Dharma Realm.' Through the power of this very sūtra, countless, immeasurable sons of the gods became stream-enterers. Son of noble family, all the tathāgatas regard whoever holds and reads this sūtra as their own son. When such a person dies in that very saṃsāra, they set him on the path to nirvāṇa."

Vajrapāṇi said:

"O Buddha, for beings who find saṃsāra hard to cross,
You pull out the stake of becoming, and with wisdom

You shatter the stake of becoming and the torrent of mind. Through the Sage's Teaching of the Dharma, evil is crushed and the excellent Dharma is practiced."

The Blessed One said, "Vajrapāṇi, that was well and thoroughly spoken. Excellent, excellent!"

Vajrapāṇi said, "What heap of merit will be gained by one who holds this sūtra, reads it, and also teaches it extensively and correctly to others?"

The Blessed One said, "Son of noble family, I declare that whoever holds this sūtra, reads it, and also teaches it extensively and correctly to others will attain ten million samādhis. He will see ten million buddhas and bodhisattvas together with their retinues. Having seen many hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas, he will honor them with vast intention. He will revere them as his teachers. He will serve them. He will make offerings to them. He will also offer them robes, alms food, bedding, medicine for the sick, and other requisites. He will also bring about the comfort of the bodhisattvas. He will also serve the community of the Saṅgha. He will dedicate those roots of virtue to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. He will also attend upon those tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas. He will respectfully listen to their teaching of the Dharma, and he will receive it, retain it, and recite it. Just like the bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi, he will overcome adversaries through his power."

"By the might of that wrathful one, Mahābala, who overcomes adversaries, may I and all sentient beings svasti svasti siddhi siddhi svāhā."

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, noble Maitreya, Mañjuśrī, noble Avalokiteśvara, and all the bodhisattvas of the Fortunate Eon; the bodhisattva, the great being Vajragarbha, and all the others gathered from the world systems of the ten directions; all the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, rākṣasas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, mahoragas, humans and nonhumans; that entire assembly, and Vajrapāṇi, rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

This concludes the Great Vehicle sūtra called Noble Mahābala.

It was translated, edited and finalized by the Indian preceptor Śīlendrabodhi, the chief editor and translator Bandé Yeshé Dé, and others.

Translator's Notes

• The mountain called □□□□□□□□□□□ is taken as Īṣādhara, one of the golden mountains around Meru. The identification is probable but not certain. Several names in the heart-mantra list and the svāhā litany are translated by meaning because a Sanskrit form could not be identified with confidence. These are notably "the Soaring One" (possibly Garuḍa), "the hand of cattle-increase," "the bringer of rain," "the son of the god of wealth" and "the goddess who turns back austerities." For "the bringer of rain," the Tibetan reads "rain-relying," likely a slip for "rain-showing/bringing." Agni is supplied as the figure surrounded by the fire sages in the southeast; the Tibetan names only the sages, but the later litany confirms Agni. The phrase "like a tawny moon" for the arrangement of the heart mantras is rendered literally. The opening "Then the Blessed One ... Vajrapāṇi" can also be read as "Then the Blessed One and the bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi"; the draft's reading is kept.
• The number "bye ba khrag khrig stong phrag brgya" is rendered loosely as "hundreds of thousands of trillions." The exact value of khrag khrig varies between Tibetan numerical lists.
• The list of harmful beings includes two items, "adepts" and "snake-holders," that do not match any standard class of spirit. They are translated literally, and their intended Sanskrit equivalents are uncertain. "Cutting grahas" renders the Tibetan literally; what the grahas cut is not stated. The epithet "Frenzied Wrathful One" follows the house rendering; the Tibetan word may be a scribal variant. The epithet "Who Overcomes Adversaries with Immeasurable Power" is taken with Mahābala, as in the earlier passage. Grammatically it could also qualify Vajrapāṇi.
• The wrathful deity □□□□□□□□□□□□ is rendered "the Frenzied Wrathful One." Its Sanskrit equivalent is uncertain, though the mantra's "ucchuṣma krodha" may correspond to it. The terms rendered "door bars, contraptions, and bolts" likely refer to magical binding devices destroyed by the vajra. "Sorcerers" (□□□□□□□) and "snake-holders" (□□□□□□□□□□) are given by their literal meaning because their Sanskrit equivalents are uncertain. □□□□□□□ is rendered pūtana and □□□□□□□□□□□ kaṭapūtana, following the standard equivalences; when the two are not paired, the house list's pūtana for □□□□□□□□□□□ is not applied. The nāga kings □□□□□ and □□□□□□□ are translated literally as "Black One" and "Wheel," since they could not be identified with confidence. □□□□□□□ is read as "ten thousand times." The list of samādhis ends without a main verb in the Tibetan. "Entering" these samādhis is implied.
• The exchange on the "general fruit" (abiding in the time of the fruit, for the sake of good qualities) is terse and obscure in the Tibetan; it is rendered literally. "Free of disease" renders bro nad, read as a form of "illness". "Collection of the Dharma" renders chos kyi phung po (Skt. dharmaskandha), a body or mass of teachings, not the dharmakāya.
• "Came forward" renders the unusual phrase □□□□□□□□□□□□□; its exact sense (approaching, assembling) is uncertain. "Like a house and like foam" follows the text as written; the "house" is an unusual item in this list of similes, and the reading may be corrupt. The phrase "the sublime attainment" interprets the bare word □□□□, "the sublime."
• "Preceded by the Dharma Realm" renders the title-like phrase "having the dharmadhātu going before." In the verse, "stake" renders a word that in ritual contexts means the kīla dagger. Here it is used figuratively for what pins beings to existence. The Tibetan does not say who sets the dying reader on the path to nirvāṇa. "They" is read as the tathāgatas of the preceding sentence.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.